The four-product routine and why most people overcomplicate it

Week 3 Lecture 2 - Looksmaxxing

Autumn 2026

What we'll cover

- Why four products cover what most people need
- Cleansers: surfactant chemistry and how to stop stripping your skin
- Sunscreen: SPF math, UVA ratings, application dose, and what “broad-spectrum” means
- Moisturizer: occlusion, humectants, and emollients
- Topical retinoids: start protocol and what to avoid in week one
- Acne treatment: salicylic acid vs benzoyl peroxide, decision logic

Why four products

The four products that cover the evidence base

AM routine:

1. Cleanser (or water rinse for normal-dry skin)
2. Moisturizer (if skin is dry or barrier-compromised)
3. Sunscreen SPF 30+, broad-spectrum

PM routine:

1. Cleanser
2. Retinoid (if using)
3. Moisturizer

Everything else is optional. Serums, toners, essences, face mists, and “boosters” are add-ons with limited or no evidence at the population level.

James Welsh (2019): "For men starting skincare, four products covers everything you need: cleanser, moisturizer, SPF in the morning, and a targeted treatment at night."

The serum problem

- Most serums are marketed with mechanism claims that do not survive scrutiny
- Vitamin C serums (L-ascorbic acid) have some evidence for brightening and antioxidant effects, but formulations degrade quickly and consistent application matters more than the brand
- “Peptide” creams: peptides are real molecules but topical penetration is limited by molecular size; evidence for skin effects is thin
- “Anti-aging” serums as a category: the FDA classifies most as cosmetics, not drugs, which means efficacy claims are not regulated

If you are spending money on serums instead of SPF and a retinoid, the evidence does not support that order of priorities.

Cleansers

Surfactant types: what each does to your skin

High-stripping (avoid on the face):

- Sodium lauryl sulfate (SLS): effective detergent, disrupts skin lipids, raises pH
- Bar soap: alkaline pH (8-10), disrupts acid mantle, appropriate for hands not face

Gentler options:

- Sodium laureth sulfate (SLES): milder than SLS
- Cocamidopropyl betaine: amphoteric surfactant, low irritation
- Amino acid surfactants (sodium cocoyl glutamate, etc.): very gentle, preserve pH

Target skin pH: 4.5-5.5. Most gentle cleansers are formulated in this range.

How often to cleanse

- Twice daily: appropriate if you have oily or acne-prone skin
- Once daily (PM only): appropriate if your skin is dry or sensitive, or if you are experiencing barrier disruption
- Morning water rinse only: legitimate for dry skin types; overnight sebum does not require detergent to remove

The instinct to cleanse more when skin looks worse is usually wrong. Barrier-damaged skin benefits from fewer cleansing sessions, not more.

Sunscreen

SPF: what the number means and what it does not

SPF (Sun Protection Factor) measures protection against UVB only.

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SPF 30: blocks ~96.7% of UVB
SPF 50: blocks ~98.0% of UVB
SPF 100: blocks ~99.0% of UVB
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The difference between SPF 30 and SPF 50 is small in absolute terms but meaningful in terms of damage allowed through. The claim that “SPF 50 is only 1% better than SPF 30” is wrong: it is 1% more UVB blocked, but that 1% represents a 33% reduction in the damage that gets through.

Michelle Wong PhD (2019): "Two clinical studies comparing SPF 85 vs SPF 50 found significantly greater sunburn protection at higher SPFs in real-world use."

Application dose is the hidden variable

Most people apply 20-50% of the dose used in SPF testing.

Dr. Sam Ellis (2022): "Most people apply 20-50% of the recommended amount of sunscreen -- at that level, an SPF 50 sunscreen delivers closer to SPF 7 protection in practice."

Tested dose: 2 mg per cm squared of skin.
Approximate amount for the face: 1/4 teaspoon (1.25 mL).

If you are using a moisturizer with SPF 15 and applying a thin layer, you are getting close to no UV protection.

UVA protection: PA ratings and broad-spectrum

SPF measures UVB only. UVA causes photoaging and penetrates glass.

PA system (Japan, Korea):

- PA+: some UVA protection
- PA++: moderate
- PA+++: high
- PA++++: highest available

EU broad-spectrum: the UVA circle logo indicates the UVA protection is at least 1/3 of the SPF value.

AAD guidance: look for “broad-spectrum” on the label as the minimum standard. Choose PA+++ or PA++++ if the system is available.

Mineral vs chemical: not a safety debate

Mineral filters (zinc oxide, titanium dioxide):

- Sit on the surface of skin and scatter/reflect UV
- Leave a white cast on darker skin tones (nano-particle formulations reduce this)
- Better for sensitive and barrier-compromised skin

Chemical (organic) filters (avobenzone, Tinosorb S, Uvinul T 150, etc.):

- Absorb UV and convert to heat; no white cast
- Modern European chemical filters (Tinosorb, Uvinul) have strong stability and UVA coverage
- US chemical filter options are more limited due to FDA approval lag

Neither type is proven to be harmful in normal use. The “chemical sunscreen is toxic” claim circulating online is not supported by toxicology data at normal use doses.

Moisturizer: three mechanisms, not one

Occlusives (petrolatum, dimethicone, squalane): form a physical film that reduces TEWL. Strongest barrier support.

Humectants (hyaluronic acid, glycerin, urea): draw water from the dermis and environment into the epidermis. Add surface hydration.

Emollients (fatty alcohols, shea butter, ceramides): fill gaps in the lipid matrix of the stratum corneum. Improve texture and flexibility.

A good moisturizer has all three. Many expensive products are mostly water and humectants. Petrolatum remains the most cost-effective occlusive available.

Salicylic acid vs benzoyl peroxide: two different targets

Salicylic acid (BHA, 0.5-2%):

- Lipophilic: penetrates the sebum-filled follicle
- Comedolytic: dissolves the keratin plug blocking the pore
- Best for: closed comedones, blackheads, mild non-inflammatory acne

Benzoyl peroxide (2.5-10%):

- Bactericidal against C. acnes: kills the bacteria driving inflammation
- Best for: inflammatory papules, pustules, cysts
- Bleaches fabric and pillow cases; use with white towels

Dr. Dray (2020): "Benzoyl peroxide kills the bacteria that causes inflammatory acne -- it's the most bactericidal OTC ingredient we have."

They work by different mechanisms and can be used together: salicylic acid in the AM, benzoyl peroxide in the PM, retinoid on alternating nights to avoid stacking too many actives.

Starting tretinoin: what to avoid in the first month

Dr. Dray (2022): "Start tretinoin two nights a week, buffer with a moisturizer if irritated, and avoid combining with exfoliating acids in the same routine during the first month."

Week 1-4 protocol:

- Apply two nights per week, on dry skin, after cleansing
- If irritated: apply moisturizer first (the “sandwich method”), then tretinoin on top
- Do not combine with AHAs, BHAs, or other exfoliants in the same session
- Do not combine with vitamin C in the same PM routine (pH conflict)
- Apply sunscreen every AM without exception

Take-aways

1. Four products cover the evidence base: cleanser, moisturizer, sunscreen, and a retinoid or acne treatment. Everything else is optional.
2. Sunscreen dose matters as much as SPF number. Apply 1/4 teaspoon to the face. Under-dosing an SPF 50 gives SPF 7 protection.
3. Gentle cleansers preserve skin pH and barrier lipids. Harsh cleansing triggers more sebum production and worsens acne.
4. Salicylic acid clears comedones. Benzoyl peroxide kills acne bacteria. They work by different mechanisms and can be used together.
5. Start tretinoin slowly: two nights per week for the first month. The purging phase is expected. Stopping sunscreen is not an option.

> "Most people apply 20-50% of the recommended amount of sunscreen -- at that level, an SPF 50 sunscreen delivers closer to SPF 7 protection in practice."

-- Dr. Sam Ellis, board-certified dermatologist, *10 Sunscreen Mistakes to Avoid*, 2022

What's next

- **Week 3 Section:** Bathroom shelf audit. Bring your products or a shelf photo.
- **Week 3 Reading:** Skincare from skin biology forward (required before section)
- **HW1 due this week:** Honest baseline audit
- **Week 4:** Hair: scalp health, hair loss, and styling for face shape